

VALLEY OF WORDS

Looking at the social evolution of Kashmir through the eyes of ordinary people who lived its history



A MISSION IN KASHMIR
by ANDREW WHITEHEAD
Viking
Price: Rs 495
Pages: 284



**IN SEARCH OF A FUTURE:
THE STORY OF KASHMIR**
by DAVID DEVADAS
Viking
Price: Rs 495, Pages: 381

■ By Amitabh Mattoo

There is something special about Kashmir. Not just the conflict or the competing nationalisms or the everyday tragedies of the last two decades. Nor the fact that in some perverse Manichean fashion, both Ayatollah Khomeini and Salman Rushdie trace their descent to the Valley. It is the manner in which Kashmir has and continues to inspire artistic and spiritual imagination: the splendour of the crafts, the epicurean delights of the *wazwaan*, and the mystique of kashmiriyat make the place and the people unique. Kashmir and Kashmiris need to be investigated, seriously, by historians, political scientists, art historians and psychologists. Yet, little systematic work has been undertaken, despite the huge resources

spent on keeping or taking Kashmir.

Kashmir also produced one of the first written historical accounts in South Asia, Kalhan's *Rajatarangini*. And yet, ironically, one of the casualties of the contemporary conflict in and over Kashmir has been the writing of its history. Combative agencies have ensured that much of what is written about the Valley is little more than propaganda. In the last few years, the only two outstanding books on Kashmir were doctoral dissertations by Mridu Rai and Chitralkha Zutshi.

The two books by David Devadas and Andrew Whitehead come, therefore, as a pleasant surprise. Both are well-known journalists, and bring to their accounts the strength of a snoop reporter. Oral sources, as we know, are

FLIGHTS OF HOPE: The mystique of kashmiriyat makes the place unique

grossly undervalued in history. Most historians are sceptical about individual testimonies and use the interview only as corroborative evidence. Human memory, we are told, is grossly unreliable. And respondents interviewed years after an event are unlikely to be good witnesses. Unfortunately, this disdain for oral sources has meant that a wealth of rich stories has disappeared. And, often in the absence of the written word, no real history can be written.

Devadas and Whitehead, thankfully, do not share this cynicism of the conservative historian. While they consulted other archival material, they gained their principal insights from interviews conducted with ordinary men and women who lived Kashmir's history. Both have attempted a sort of "subaltern" view of Kashmir's history. Ordinary men and women, and not leaders, find considerable space in the book. Whitehead is a believer in "history from below", while it is probably a part of Devadas's training as a reporter. The similarities end here.

In Search of a Future is a more ambitious book. It seeks to cover the com-

